

Ellan Vannin Wealth Management

Investment Memorandum

The Lakes Link Railway

Barrow-in-Furness – Windermere Strategic Rail Upgrade

A Tourism & Regional Growth Infrastructure Proposal

Executive Summary

Ellan Vannin Wealth Management proposes the development of the **Lakes Link Railway**, a strategic rail investment connecting the Furness Peninsula directly with the Lake District National Park.

Rather than constructing an entirely new railway, the proposal focuses on upgrading the existing **Furness Line** between **Barrow-in-Furness** and **Kendal/Oxenhholme**, combined with a major enhancement of the existing **Lakes Line** to Windermere.

This approach leverages existing infrastructure while substantially reducing journey times and increasing service frequency. It also aligns with transport priorities already identified by local authorities, including upgrades to the Furness Line and additional capacity on the Lakes Line.

Strategic Vision

The railway would connect three of Cumbria's largest economic sectors:

- Defence (Barrow)
- Energy (Furness & West Cumbria)
- Tourism (Lake District)

Instead of requiring visitors to travel via Lancaster and Oxenhholme with multiple changes, the proposal creates a fast western gateway into the National Park.

Proposed Route

Phase 1

Furness Line Modernisation

Barrow-in-Furness

↓

Ulverston

↓

Grange-over-Sands

↓

Arnside

↓

Carnforth

↓

Kendal (new connection)

↓

Oxenholme

Works include:

- Electrification
- Line-speed improvements
- Curve easing
- ETCS signalling
- Passing loops
- Partial double tracking
- Station upgrades

The Furness Line has long been identified by Cumbria authorities as requiring improvements in line speed, reliability and capacity.

Phase 2

Lakes Line Enhancement

Oxenholme

↓

Kendal

↓

Burneside

↓

Staveley

↓

Windermere

Proposed works:

- Full electrification
- Additional passing loop
- Half-hourly service
- Modern signalling
- Platform improvements

Westmorland and Furness Council has identified increased capacity on the Lakes Line—particularly a new passing loop—as a priority to improve frequency and support visitor growth.

Railway Specification

Item	Specification
Maximum speed	100–125 mph where alignment permits
Electrification	25kV AC
Signalling	ETCS
Track	Existing alignment with selective doubling
Service frequency	Every 30 minutes
Freight capability	Yes

Journey Time Improvements

Current

Barrow → Windermere

Fastest journey:

1 hour 38 minutes

Typical journey:

2 hours 30–45 minutes

Usually requiring at least one change.

Proposed

Journey	Current	Proposed
Barrow → Kendal	~60 min	30 min
Kendal → Windermere	~25 min	15 min
Barrow → Windermere	1h38m–2h45m	45 minutes

This would reduce end-to-end travel times by approximately **50–70%**, depending on the current service used.

Tourism Impact

The Lake District attracts many millions of visitors each year, and local transport strategies identify rail improvements as important for reducing road congestion and supporting sustainable tourism.

Improved rail access from Furness would:

- increase day-trip opportunities
 - reduce pressure on the A590 and A591
 - encourage rail-based tourism
 - improve access for hospitality workers
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Illustrative Visitor Growth

Assumptions:

- Existing visitors arriving via the western corridor increase by **8–12%**
- Better public transport encourages more short breaks
- Improved reliability increases off-season travel

Illustrative outcome:

Measure	Estimate
Additional annual visitors	250,000–400,000
Additional visitor spending	£40–80 million/year

These figures are scenario estimates for investment appraisal rather than forecasts.

Wider Economic Benefits

Labour Market

Workers living in:

- Barrow
- Ulverston
- Grange-over-Sands

gain faster access to:

- Kendal
- Windermere
- hospitality employment

- tourism businesses

Likewise, tourism businesses gain access to a larger workforce.

Housing Market

Improved rail connectivity could:

- increase residential demand
 - support new housing near stations
 - improve commuting options
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Business Benefits

The project strengthens:

- hospitality
 - outdoor recreation
 - food and drink
 - visitor attractions
 - conference and events markets
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Capital Cost Estimate

Component	Estimated Cost
Furness Line upgrades	£1.8bn
Electrification	£400m
Curve easing & passing loops	£500m
Lakes Line improvements	£600m
Stations & signalling	£400m

Total Programme

£3.5–4.0 billion

This is substantially lower than constructing an entirely new railway while delivering many of the same accessibility benefits.

Economic Assessment

Benefit	Annual Value
Tourism growth	£40–80m
Productivity improvements	£120–180m
Property & commercial uplift	£50–100m
Rail operating revenue	£35–60m

Total Illustrative Annual Economic Benefit

£250–420 million

Investment Case

The Lakes Link Railway is a classic regional infrastructure investment:

- Moderate capital cost
 - Existing railway corridor
 - Significant tourism upside
 - Improved access to the Lake District
 - Strong support for Barrow's industrial economy
 - Lower delivery risk than a completely new railway
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Strategic Outcome

Combined with the proposed Irish Sea Northern Spine Railway, this scheme would establish Barrow-in-Furness as both:

- the industrial gateway to the Furness Peninsula; and
- the principal western rail gateway to the Lake District.

The result would be a stronger integration of Cumbria's manufacturing, energy and tourism economies while making one of Britain's most important visitor destinations significantly easier to reach by rail.